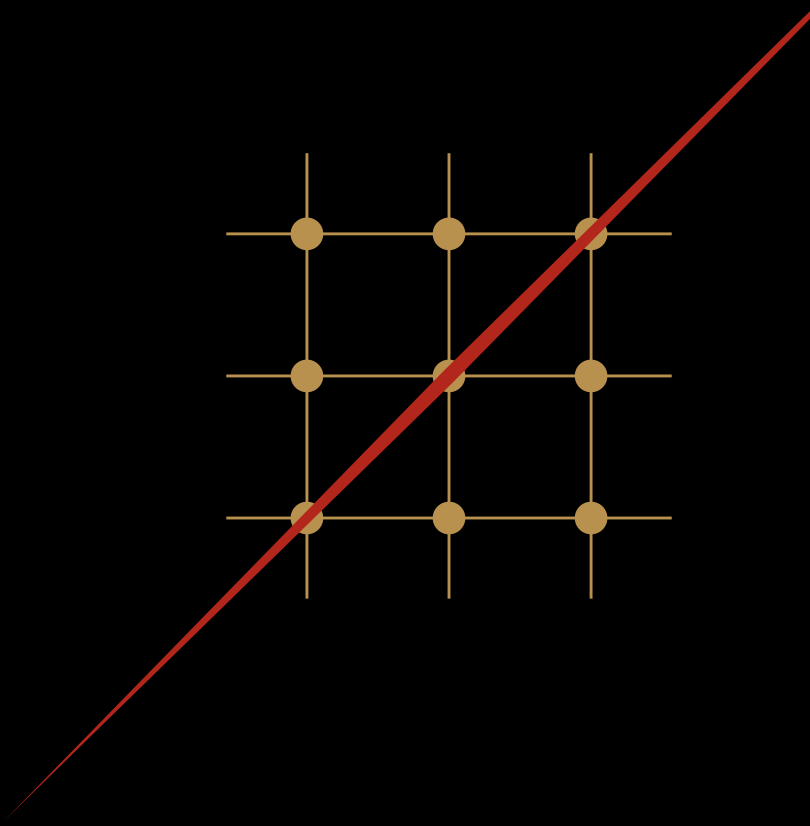


The Absolute Value of the Wound

Lacerative Order and the Ethics of Re-signation in Clive Barker's Hellraiser

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Abstract

This thesis argues that Clive Barker's *The Hellbound Heart* (1986) and its cinematic transposition *Hellraiser* (1987) articulate a coherent and hitherto unformalized metaphysics, here termed *lacerative order*, whose central operation, performed by the puzzle-box and embodied in the Cenobites of the Order of the Gash, is the annihilation of sign: the conversion of valenced experience (pleasure and pain, good and evil, angel and demon) into unsigned magnitude, or intensity. Modelling this operation as an absolute-value operator, the study demonstrates that its formal properties (non-injectivity, idempotence, non-invertibility) correspond with unusual precision to the mythos's governing doctrines: the indivisibility of pleasure and pain, the irreversibility of initiation, and the impossibility of return without an external act of decision.

Genealogically, the thesis reconstructs three lineages that Western thought has held in opposition and that the Order of the Gash fuses into a single institution: a transgressive lineage (Sade, Bataille, Foucault); an ascetic-mystical lineage (desert cenobitism, Teresa of Ávila, Julian of Norwich, Nietzsche's ascetic ideal); and a combinatorial-rationalist lineage (Llull, Kircher, Leibniz, Descartes, Kant). Comparative chapters situate the mythos against Dante, Marlowe, Milton, Goethe, Lewis, Machen, Lovecraft, Kafka, Mirbeau, Cronenberg, and Laugier, and against the mythic and scriptural figures of Pandora, Daedalus, Marsyas, Osiris, Zagreus, Xipe Totec, Bluebeard, Jacob, and Lazarus.

The argument proceeds on three levels. Metaphysically, it distinguishes two limits at which the sign of experience vanishes, the nirvanic zero and the cenobitic infinite, and locates Barker's achievement at the second. Generically, it reads *Hellraiser* as horror's autotheory: a text that stages its own spectatorship, fusing two of what Linda Williams calls the body genres, pornography and horror, while expelling the third, melodrama, whose bodily sign is tears. Political-economically, it argues that intensity functions as the general equivalent of

affect, the libidinal analogue of the money-form, so that the Configuration, made by Lemarchand (*le marchand*), appears as the commodity whose metaphysical subtleties are literal.

Against the operation of the Gash, the thesis isolates a counter-operation it names *re-signation*: the restoration of sign through lament, mourning, and the recognition of the face, enacted by Kirsty Cotton and inscribed, with unremarked irony, in the very name of the Lament Configuration. *Hellraiser* thereby emerges neither as a cautionary fable against excess nor as an apology for transgression, but as a dialectic between the Gash and the Lament: an inquiry into whether the infinite that desire seeks is real, and whether the human is the creature that, having glimpsed it, chooses to weep.

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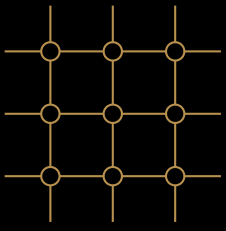
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Introduction

The Box as Problem

The Paradox of the Solved Object
Corpus and Method
State of the Field
Architecture of the Argument

The Paradox of the Solved Object

The founding image of the mythos is an act of concentration. Barker's novella opens with Frank Cotton so absorbed in the puzzle of Lemarchand's box that he fails to register the first tolling of a great bell, the sound with which the elsewhere announces that it has been reached. The scene contains the whole problem in miniature. A man performs an operation of pure order, manual, combinatorial, and patient, the labour of watchmakers, cryptographers, and scholastic memory-artists; and the operation's success is an opening, a breach first in the room, then in the world, and finally in the man. To solve is to open; to order is to wound. The present thesis takes this paradox not as a genre conceit but as a philosophical proposition, and contends that Barker develops it with a rigour that the critical literature, preoccupied with sexual allegory and with the spectacle of the opened body, has not yet recognized.

The proposition may be stated in advance. *Hellraiser* articulates a lacerative metaphysics in which the highest form of order and the deepest form of laceration are identical rather than opposed. Its central operation is the annihilation of sign. The Cenobites, who define themselves in the 1987 film as "Explorers in the further regions of experience. Demons to some. Angels to others," do not invert the values of pleasure and pain as a satanist inverts those of good and evil. They abolish the sign that distinguishes the two and retain only magnitude. What the box opens onto is experience stripped of valence: intensity as such. The chapters that follow formalize this operation, trace its genealogy, test it against the comparative record of infernal and mythological fiction, and finally oppose to it the counter-operation that the mythos itself supplies, which this study names *re-signation*.

Corpus and Method

The primary corpus comprises *The Hellbound Heart*, first published in the anthology *Night Visions 3* (1986), and *Hellraiser* (1987), written and directed by Barker. *Hellbound: Hellraiser II* (1988), made under Barker's executive aegis, is treated as a secondary canonical text. The later se-

quels, Barker's valedictory novel *The Scarlet Gospels* (2015), and David Bruckner's 2022 reboot are read as reception history, valuable chiefly as an index of how faithfully the mythos's central operation has been preserved or how thoroughly it has been betrayed.

Method requires a distinction among three registers of evidence. The first is documented sources: the Faust tradition, already the matter of Barker's experimental short *The Forbidden* (1978); the devotional iconography of Catholicism; the punk and sadomasochistic subcultures that Barker has named among the Cenobites' visual origins; and the Gothic and surrealist inheritances of his theatrical and painterly practice. The second is a genealogical field: the ensemble of thinkers whose problems the text inherits whether or not its author consulted them. Genealogy, in the Nietzschean and Foucauldian sense, reconstructs descent (*Herkunft*) rather than proving influence; it asks what a text must presuppose in order to mean what it means. The thesis therefore does not claim that Barker read Bataille, Kierkegaard, or Llull, only that his fiction occupies the problem-space they defined. The third register, onomastic and iconographic resonance, is employed heuristically and flagged as such throughout. A name such as Kircher or Lemarchand does not prove a source; it opens an archive, and the warrant for opening it lies in the coherence of what it discloses.

The text is treated, finally, as philosophical fiction in the sense Gilles Deleuze gave to Sade and Masoch, whom he regarded less as patients than as clinicians, authors of symptomatologies more exact than the psychiatry that borrowed their names. Barker, on this view, is a symptomatologist of desire's relation to the infinite.

State of the Field

Scholarship on Barker has developed along four principal axes. The first, represented by Linda Badley's studies of horror and the body (1995; 1996) and Philip Brophy's account of "horrality" (1986), situates *Hellraiser* within the body-horror cinema of the 1980s and reads the opened body as the genre's new semiotic surface. The second, exemplified by Harry M. Benshoff's *Monsters in the Closet* (1997), attends to

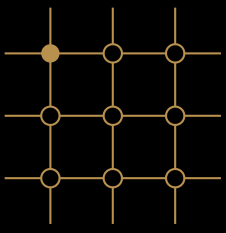
Barker as an openly gay author and reads the Cenobites against the sexual politics of the AIDS era. The third, feminist and psychoanalytic, draws on Carol Clover's Final Girl, Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine, and Julia Kristeva's abjection to read Kirsty and Julia as poles of gendered spectatorship. The fourth, biographical and production-historical, includes Douglas E. Winter's *Clive Barker: The Dark Fantastic* (2001), Gary Hoppenstand's study of the short fiction (1994), and Paul Kane's survey of the films and their legacy (2006).

Each axis is productive; none formalizes the operation at the mythos's centre, and none reconstructs the convergence of monastic, combinatorial, and transgressive traditions in the single figure of the Order of the Gash. Two textual facts in particular have passed largely without comment. The first is the persistent motif of tears, from the lead Cenobite's contempt for Kirsty's weeping, dismissed as a waste of suffering, to Frank's final citation of John 11:35. The second is the semantic drift by which the novella's Lemarchand Configuration, named for a merchant, becomes in the films the Lament Configuration, named for grief. This study argues that these two facts constitute the hinge of the mythos's ethics.

Architecture of the Argument

Chapter One establishes the textual genealogy from novella to film and its historical matrix in Britain around 1986. Chapter Two reads Frank Cotton as the terminal figure of signed hedonism, from Epicurus and Bentham through Kierkegaard's aesthete and Huysmans's Des Esseintes to Augustine's restless heart and the antinomian completism of the Carpocratians and Jacob Frank. Chapter Three develops a philosophy of the Configuration as a threshold-machine, drawing on Pandora, Daedalus, Bluebeard, the combinatorial arts, Freud's *fort/da*, Deleuze's distinction between sadistic institution and masochistic contract, and the Bataille–Foucault theory of limit and transgression. Chapter Four reconstructs the Order of the Gash as a monastery, an ascetic ideal, an iconography, a numinous ambivalence, and, through Marsyas and Dante, as the identity of Apollonian form and Dionysian

wound. Chapter Five turns to flesh, skin, and abjection; Chapter Six undertakes a comparative infernology. Chapter Seven states the original thesis in formal terms. Chapter Eight develops the counter-operation of tears, mourning, and re-signation, and reads *Hellraiser* as horror's autotheory. Chapter Nine reconstructs the libidinal political economy of the box and closes with a coda on the Configuration's contemporary afterlife.



Chapter One

From Lemarchand to Lament

Textual Genealogy and Historical Matrix

1.1 Novella and Film: Five Transpositions

1.2 Onomastics as Heuristic

1.3 The Expanded Canon and the Return of the Sign

1.4 Historical Matrix: Britain, circa 1986

1.1 *Novella and Film: Five Transpositions*

The mythos originates in a novella by an author already celebrated for the six volumes of the *Books of Blood* (1984–85) and already disillusioned with cinema: the two films made from his scripts by George Pavlou, *Underworld* (1985) and *Rawhead Rex* (1986), persuaded Barker to direct the next adaptation himself, and *The Hellbound Heart* was written, on most accounts, with its filming already in view. The passage from page to screen is therefore not a dilution but a second authorial act. Five transpositions repay analysis, because each displaces the text's philosophical centre of gravity.

The first concerns kinship. In the novella, Frank's brother is Rory, and Kirsty is Rory's friend, quietly in love with him; in the film, Rory becomes Larry and Kirsty becomes his daughter. An erotic triangle thereby becomes a family romance. The rivalry of brothers acquires its biblical templates, Cain and Abel, Jacob and Esau, and the climax, in which Frank wears Larry's skin to deceive Kirsty, becomes a test of filial recognition: the daughter must distinguish the father from the paternal surface.

The second concerns provenance. The novella's Frank learns of and procures the box through a European intermediary named Kircher; the film relocates the acquisition to an orientalized bazaar and opens and closes on a merchant who sells it. The hermetic archive of Europe, indexed by a name that cannot fail to recall the Jesuit polymath Athanasius Kircher, is exchanged for the colonial imaginary of the Orient as a reservoir of forbidden pleasure, and the box's circulation as a commodity becomes the film's structural frame.

The third concerns nomenclature. The novella's Lemarchand Configuration becomes, across the films, the Lament Configuration: an object named for a merchant becomes an object named for grief. The merchant does not vanish. *Hellraiser: Bloodline* (1996) literalizes the etymology by tracing Lemarchand's descendants as a family named Merchant. The doubled name, commerce and lament, is one of the hinges of this thesis.

The fourth concerns the locus of intensity. In the novella, the Cenobites' gift is principally interior: Frank's sensorium is amplified until every perception, however slight, becomes unbearable, a hyperaesthesia that annuls the difference between caress and wound. The film externalizes this as spectacle, with hooks and chains drawing the flesh toward the corners of the room, because cinema must render intensity visible. The camera thus becomes a second Configuration, converting interior magnitude into exterior sight.

The fifth concerns the voice of the Order. The novella's Cenobites are sexually indeterminate, and its gridded and pinned figure speaks with a voice the narrator likens to a young girl's. The film gives that figure Doug Bradley's measured, liturgical baritone, consolidating the androgyne into a celebrant. The production and its audience came to call him Pinhead; Barker's late novel names him the Hell Priest. The androgynous principle survives in the film's female Cenobite and in the novella's designation of the Order's members as theologians, but the cinematic Order acquires a priest.

The bell survives both versions. Its tolling, which Frank fails to hear in the novella's first sentence, recurs in the film as the acoustic signature of the elsewhere. Chapter Four will argue that it is a monastic bell, and that its meaning is canonical in the strict sense: it summons to an Office.

1.2 *Onomastics as Heuristic*

The proper names of the film form a constellation whose coherence exceeds what coincidence would predict, though not what the unconscious of a culture might supply. Their value here is organizational rather than evidentiary. *Frank* condenses candour, the freedom of the Frankish freeman, the reassembled body of Mary Shelley's Frankenstein, and, most suggestively, Jacob Frank, the eighteenth-century antinomian messiah who taught redemption through transgression (Chapter Two). *Julia* echoes Sade's Juliette, the sister who prospers through vice (Chapter Five). *Kirsty*, a Scots diminutive of Christina, names the Christian, and in *Hellbound* she undertakes a descent into

Hell that reprises the Harrowing (Chapter Five). *Larry*, the familiar form of Lawrence, recalls the deacon martyred on a gridiron, whose instrument returns as the grid incised upon the lead Cenobite's head (Chapter Four). *Cotton* names an absorbent fibre, apt for a family whose floorboards drink blood, and a commodity whose history in Barker's native Liverpool is inseparable from the Atlantic economy of enslaved bodies (Chapter Nine). *Lemarchand* is *le marchand*; *Kircher* is a Jesuit of the combinatorial arts (Chapter Three). These are resonances, not intentions. Their justification lies in the arguments they make possible.

1.3 *The Expanded Canon and the Return of the Sign*

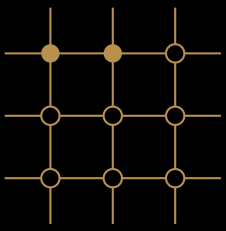
The sequels constitute a reception history that can be read as a single process: the gradual return of the sign that the original operation abolished. *Hellbound: Hellraiser II* (1988) deepens the cosmology and humanizes the Order at once. It supplies the geometric deity Leviathan, lord of a labyrinthine Hell rendered in the idiom of Piranesi's *Carceri* and Escher; it introduces Dr Channard, a psychiatrist whose clinic becomes an antechamber of the cenobium; it gives the lead Cenobite a human past as Captain Elliot Spencer, an officer of the First World War generation; and it allows Kirsty to restore that memory with a photograph. The humanization is itself an act of re-signation, re-inscribing the Cenobites within the moral economy of persons. *Hellraiser III: Hell on Earth* (1992) severs Pinhead from Spencer and releases a purified, theatrical evil, staged most memorably in a blasphemous church sequence; the Cenobite becomes a villain, which is to say a figure with a negative sign. *Hellraiser: Bloodline* (1996) traces the box to the toymaker Philip Lemarchand and his Sadean patron, the Duc de L'Isle, and ends with a counter-device, the Elysium Configuration, designed to annihilate darkness with light: a Manichaean re-signing of the entire mythos. The direct-to-video sequels, from *Hellraiser: Inferno* (2000) to *Hellraiser: Judgment* (2018), frequently cast the Cenobites as instruments of retributive judgment upon the guilty, converting the Order into a moralizing tribunal of Dantean type.

Barker's *The Scarlet Gospels* (2015) restores the figure's scale while redirecting it toward political theology: the Hell Priest wages war upon the world's magicians in pursuit of their knowledge and conceives the ambition of supplanting Lucifer himself, an ambition the novel answers with catastrophe. Bruckner's 2022 reboot, re-conceiving the lead Cenobite as the Priest and reorganizing the box as a sequence of configurations that each demand a victim, recovers much of the original ambivalence and adds a wealthy seeker of the box's gift, a figure Chapter Nine reads as capital's own Frank Cotton. The thesis advanced here explains the franchise's celebrated decline as the progressive restoration of sign: the more the Cenobites are made evil, or just, the less they are Cenobites.

1.4 *Historical Matrix: Britain, circa 1986*

The novella and film emerged at a conjuncture that pressed upon precisely the questions the mythos poses. The Housing Act 1980 had inaugurated the Right to Buy and the rhetoric of a property-owning democracy; the film's couple move into a family house and set about refurbishing it, so that the domestic interior becomes simultaneously an asset and a crypt. On 27 October 1986, the City of London's deregulatory "Big Bang" dissolved the boundaries that had segmented its markets, in the same year that Barker imagined a box that dissolves the boundary between pleasure and pain. The AIDS epidemic, addressed by the government's "Don't Die of Ignorance" campaign of 1986–87 with its imagery of tombstones and icebergs, had made the body visible as a site at which desire and death are transmissible. The moral panic over "video nasties" had already produced the Video Recordings Act 1984, a statutory apparatus for licensing the depiction of pain on domestic screens. And in 1987, the year of the film's release, the police investigation later known as Operation Spanner began; it culminated in *R v Brown* (1993), in which the House of Lords held, by a majority of three to two, that consent affords no defence to charges of assault occasioning actual bodily harm in sadomasochistic encounters.

To this conjuncture should be added the subcultural iconography Barker himself invoked: the safety pin driven through cheek and ear by the punk body of 1976–77, a sign of refusal turned ornament; the leather, harness, and ritual formality of the sadomasochistic club; and the Catholic devotional image of the pierced and opened saint. *Hellraiser* thus appeared where three forces met: a state that re-signs pain through regulation, censorship, and the law of consent; a market that deregulates value; and an epidemic that conjoins eros and mortality. Against all three, the Cenobites figure a jurisdiction in which consent is total and irrevocable. The box, in this light, is a consent form that cannot be withdrawn.



Chapter Two

The Hedonic Impasse

Frank Cotton and the Exhaustion of Signed Pleasure

2.1 Epicurus, Bentham, and the Calculus of Purity

2.2 The Aesthete's Boredom: Kierkegaard, Huysmans, Wilde

2.3 The Restless Heart: Augustine Inverted

2.4 Antinomian Completion: Carpocrates, Sade, Jacob Frank

2.1 *Epicurus, Bentham, and the Calculus of Purity*

The novella presents Frank's life before the box as a catalogue of exhaustion: travel, intoxication, debauchery, a career of sensation pursued until each source is spent and the world offers nothing that has not already been tasted. Frank is the hedonist at the end of hedonism, and classical hedonism had foreseen his impasse. Epicurus distinguished kinetic pleasures, the pleasures of stimulation and motion, from katastematic pleasures, the stable condition of *aponia* (absence of bodily pain) and *ataraxia* (absence of mental disturbance), and ranked the latter above the former. The *Letter to Menoeceus* is explicit that the end of life is not the enjoyment of the profligate but freedom from pain in the body and trouble in the soul. Epicurean hedonism is thus a hedonism of the sign: its telos is the removal of the negative, and its wisdom consists in recognizing that the positive cannot be indefinitely increased. Frank inverts the Epicurean ordering, pursuing kinetic pleasure to the point at which nothing negative remains to be removed and nothing positive remains to be added.

Jeremy Bentham's felicific calculus (1789) allows the impasse to be stated with precision. Bentham assessed a pleasure or pain along seven dimensions: intensity, duration, certainty, propinquity, fecundity, purity, and extent. *Purity* he defined as the chance that a sensation has of not being followed by sensations of the opposite kind. Purity is, in effect, the stability of the sign. Frank's career maximizes intensity at the expense of purity, tolerating hangovers, diseases, and disgusts as the price of ever sharper stimulations. The Cenobites offer this trajectory its limit: maximal intensity at zero purity, a sensation not followed by its opposite but coincident with it. The calculus does not fail because the Cenobites are irrational; it fails because they drive one of its variables to the point at which another becomes undefined. *Hellraiser* is, in a strict sense, a *reductio ad absurdum* of the felicific calculus, and Marx's sardonic inclusion of Bentham among the presiding deities of the marketplace (Chapter Nine) will show that the reduction is not merely ethical.

2.2 *The Aesthete's Boredom: Kierkegaard, Huysmans, Wilde*

Kierkegaard's *Either/Or* (1843) supplies the existential physiognomy of Frank's condition. Its aesthete, the pseudonymous A, diagnoses boredom as the root of all evil and proposes the "rotation method," a technique for varying not the field of enjoyment but the manner of its cultivation, so that arbitrariness itself becomes the last refinement. A's essay on Mozart's *Don Giovanni* finds in the seducer's catalogue, the famous tally of conquests, the form of aesthetic infinity: quantity without quality, a list that can be extended indefinitely because no item on it is ever possessed. Frank's biography is a catalogue aria. Kierkegaard's *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844) adds the decisive category. The demonic, there, is *det Indesluttede*, inclosing reserve: the self that shuts itself up against the good and communicates only involuntarily, through the sudden. No object in literature better emblematizes inclosing reserve than a sealed box that opens suddenly. The aesthetic stage, pushed to its terminus, does not lead to the ethical, as Kierkegaard's judge William hoped; it leads to the demonic, and the demonic has a shape.

Joris-Karl Huysmans's *À rebours* (1884) had already given that terminus a decor. Des Esseintes, retreating to Fontenay to cultivate the artificial against the natural, has a living tortoise gilded and encrusted with precious stones, and the creature dies beneath its ornament. The image anticipates, with uncanny exactness, the jewelled pins that the novella drives into the lead Cenobite's flesh: ornament that is also a wound, luxury as laceration. Barbey d'Aurevilly famously remarked that after such a book its author could only choose between the muzzle of a pistol and the foot of the Cross. Huysmans chose the Cross. Frank chooses a third object that is both at once, an instrument of death that is also a reliquary. Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890–91) completes the lineage. Lord Henry's "new Hedonism" promises that a life of sensation can be lived without consequence, and the consequence is displaced onto a portrait concealed in the old schoolroom at the top of the house. Frank, hidden in the upstairs room, is a Dorian whose portrait is his own flesh.

2.3 *The Restless Heart: Augustine Inverted*

The novella's title reads as a mutilated citation of the most famous sentence in Christian autobiography. Augustine opens the *Confessions* by addressing God: *fecisti nos ad te et inquietum est cor nostrum donec requiescat in te*, "you have made us for yourself, and our heart is restless until it rests in you." Barker retains the restless heart and alters its terminus. For Augustine, concupiscence is the infinite longing of a creature made for the infinite, misdirected toward finite goods that cannot satisfy it; its restlessness is diagnostic, the symptom of a misplaced vocation. Book Two adds the scene of the pear theft, in which the young Augustine steals fruit he does not want, for love of the theft itself, and discovers in himself the desire for transgression as its own object.

Frank's error, in Augustinian terms, is to seek the infinite in sensation. The scandal of the Cenobitic answer is that the infinite in sensation exists. Barker grants the hedonist precisely the premise that Augustine denied, namely that a finite medium, the flesh, can bear an infinite content, and makes the truth of that premise the horror. The heart's restlessness does find rest, but the rest it finds is Hell; and Hell, in this cosmology, is not the absence of the infinite but its presence in the wrong register.

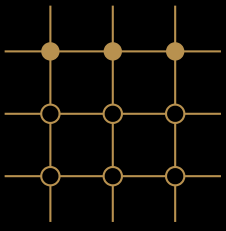
2.4 *Antinomian Completion: Carpocrates, Sade, Jacob Frank*

A further lineage reveals that Frank's hedonism is secretly soteriological. Irenaeus of Lyon (*Adversus haereses* I.25) reports that the second-century Carpocratians taught that souls must pass through every kind of action before they can be released from the cycle of embodiment; whoever has not done everything must be born again until the catalogue is complete. Libertinism, on this doctrine, is not indulgence but discipline, the methodical exhaustion of the possible as a condition of liberation. Sade's *Les 120 Journées de Sodome* (1785) secularizes the same ambition: six hundred passions, arranged in four ascending classes and narrated across four months within the sealed château of Silling, constitute an exhaustive inventory whose completion is the libertines' project. Frank is a Carpocratian without a theology and a Sadean without a

château. His travels are the itinerary of a soul attempting to complete the catalogue, and the box is promised to him as its remainder.

The most suggestive resonance is with Jacob Frank (1726–1791), the Polish-Jewish heir of the Sabbatian movement, whose followers practised ritual transgression as a messianic discipline. Gershom Scholem's essay "Redemption Through Sin" (1937) reconstructed the theology of this "holy sin": the paradox of a commandment fulfilled through its violation, and of a redemption reached only by descending into the abyss of impurity in order to liberate the sparks of holiness imprisoned there. The homonymy between Frank Cotton and Jacob Frank is a resonance, not a source. What it organizes is decisive: Frank's quest is not merely appetitive but redemptive, an unwitting enactment of redemption through sin whose descent, unlike the Frankists', finds no spark at the bottom.

The conclusion of this chapter can now be stated. Frank's impasse is not that he desires too much but that he desires within the sign. He wants pleasure, positively valued, and more of it; his entire career presupposes that intensity and goodness rise together. The Cenobites honour his desire by abolishing the sign. Their gift is exactly what he asked for, minus the one assumption he never examined.



Chapter Three

The Machine of the Threshold

A Philosophy of the Configuration

3.1 Mythic Archaeology of the Forbidden Container
3.2 Ars Combinatoria: The Lullian Engine
3.3 Fort/Da and the Soul of the Toy
3.4 Contract and Institution: Deleuze's Distinction Undone
3.5 Limit and Transgression: The Hand-Held Limit

3.1 *Mythic Archaeology of the Forbidden Container*

The Configuration descends from the oldest forbidden containers in Western myth, and the descent is complicated by a philological accident. In Hesiod's *Works and Days*, Pandora opens not a box but a *pithos*, a storage jar, releasing evils into the world while Hope (*Elpis*) remains beneath the lid. The "box" is a Renaissance artefact: as Dora and Erwin Panofsky showed, Erasmus conflated Pandora's jar with the *pyxis* of Psyche, the casket that Apuleius's heroine is sent to fetch from Proserpina in the underworld. Lemarchand's box thus inherits a humanist misreading, and its two ancestors illuminate different halves of the mythos. Pandora's vector is centrifugal: evils escape into the world. The Configuration's vector is centripetal: the opener is drawn into the elsewhere. Psyche, by contrast, opens a box that came from the underworld, out of curiosity about the beauty it contains, and falls into a Stygian sleep from which only Eros can wake her. She is Kirsty's ancestor more than Frank's: the curious soul who handles an infernal object and must be returned by love. What remains inside Pandora's jar is hope; Chapter Eight will argue that what remains inside the Configuration, once it is closed, is lament.

Daedalus supplies the artisan. For Pasiphaë, enamoured of a bull, he built a hollow wooden cow, a device for consummating a monstrous desire; for the Minotaur that desire produced, he built the labyrinth; for himself and Icarus, he built wings. The craftsman's device for transgressive desire generates first the monster and then the architecture that contains it, and *Hellbound*'s labyrinthine Hell closes the analogy with an exactness that suggests inheritance. Lemarchand is Daedalus: the maker whose ingenuity serves desires he need not share, and whose artefacts outlast every use to which they are put.

Charles Perrault's "La Barbe bleue" (1697) supplies the domestic template. A wife is given the keys to every room and forbidden one; she opens it to find the floor clotted with blood, and the key, dropped in her terror, bears a stain that no scrubbing will remove because the key is enchanted. The forbidden upstairs room, the bloodied floor, the small object that cannot be cleansed of what it has opened: *Hellraiser* re-

assembles Bluebeard's chamber in a London house. Angela Carter's "The Bloody Chamber" (1979) had already re-eroticized the tale through a Sadean marquis, and had ended it with the heroine's mother riding to the rescue. The rescue is matrilineal. In *Hellraiser*, Kirsty's mother is dead, and the daughter must perform the rescue herself.

3.2 *Ars Combinatoria: The Lullian Engine*

The novella makes Lemarchand a maker of singing birds, which is to say an automatist, and the detail places the box within the Enlightenment culture of mechanical wonder: Jacques de Vaucanson's flute-player and digesting duck (1738–39), the Jaquet-Droz family's writing automaton of the 1770s. Freud's essay on the uncanny (1919) would locate one of its paradigms in Hoffmann's automaton Olympia, the mechanism mistaken for a soul. The box is an automaton of the threshold: its panels move under the hand, its mechanism answers manipulation, and it sings, after its fashion, when solved.

A deeper lineage runs through the combinatorial arts. Ramon Llull's *Ars* (c. 1305) used rotating concentric figures to combine the divine attributes and so generate, mechanically, every true proposition. Athanasius Kircher, whose surname the novella's intermediary bears, extended the project in his *Ars Magna Sciendi* (1669) and built literal boxes of combination: the *Arca Musarithmica*, a chest of tablets for composing music by permutation, and the *Organum Mathematicum*, a chest of rods for calculation. Leibniz's *Dissertatio de arte combinatoria* (1666) dreamed of a universal characteristic in which all thought would become calculation. Roland Barthes's *Sade, Fourier, Loyola* (1971) completes the genealogy by grouping the libertine, the utopian, and the founder of the Jesuits as "logothetes," founders of languages built by enumeration, ordering, and combination: Sade's orgies are arranged as figures and postures, a grammar of bodies; Loyola's *Spiritual Exercises* are a rule-bound procedure for producing a vision. Kircher, a Jesuit, is Loyola's son; the word *configuration* belongs to this lexicon.

The Configuration is accordingly a Lullian engine of the passions. Llull's machine, completed, would yield every truth; Lemarchand's,

completed, yields the one sensation that contains all others. It is the combinatorial dream of totality transposed from knowledge to experience, and its horror lies in the fact that it works.

3.3 *Fort/Da and the Soul of the Toy*

In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), Freud describes his grandson throwing a wooden reel on a string out of sight with a long *o-o-o-o* (*fort*, "gone") and retrieving it with a joyful *da* ("there"), mastering his mother's absences by staging them. The game is the founding scene of the repetition compulsion. *Hellraiser* is structured as a *fort/da*: the film opens and closes on the box's sale, returning it to circulation as the child returns the reel; Kirsty, solving and then re-solving the puzzle, summons the Cenobites and sends them away. *Hellraiser: Bloodline* makes Lemarchand a toymaker, and the designation is exact. The box is a toy in the philosophical sense Baudelaire gave the word in "Morale du joujou" (1853): an object children twist, shake, and finally break open in the wish to see its soul, falling into melancholy when they find nothing there. Baudelaire located the origin of metaphysics in the broken toy. Frank breaks open the toy to see its soul, and the soul of the toy is Hell. The Configuration synthesizes Freud's reel and Baudelaire's doll: it is the toy that, when its soul is sought, makes absence absolute.

3.4 *Contract and Institution: Deleuze's Distinction Undone*

In *Présentation de Sacher-Masoch* (1967), Deleuze argued that sadism and masochism are not complementary halves of a single perversion but heterogeneous worlds, and that "sadomasochism" is a semiological error. Sade thinks in institutions, Masoch in contracts; the sadist demonstrates, the masochist persuades and educates; sadistic apathy differs from masochistic coldness; Sade's time is acceleration, Masoch's is suspense. Lacan's "Kant avec Sade" (1963) added that the sadist enjoys nothing for himself but makes himself the instrument of the Other's jouissance, executing a maxim with the impersonality of Kantian practical reason.

Frank approaches the box as a masochist approaches a contract. He prepares the room as a scene, consents in advance, and expects the pleasures he has been promised, imagined in the novella as compliant bodies arranged for his use; he believes himself the author of the scenario. He meets instead a Sadean institution, impersonal, unhurried, indifferent to his consent once given, administering an impersonal law with the apathy Lacan identified. Yet this institution is summoned by a quasi-contractual act, honours the bargain Kirsty later strikes, and threatens her with the consequences of its breach. The Order of the Gash is what Deleuze held impossible: a contract that founds an institution, and an institution that keeps contracts. *Hellraiser* does not confuse the two structures; it sequences them, so that a masochian contract (entry) opens onto a sadean institution (duration), which is exited only by a second contract (Kirsty's bargain). The box is the hinge between the two economies.

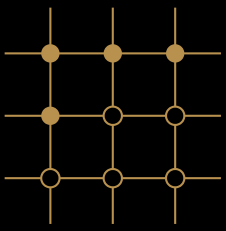
Dimension	*Sade (after Deleuze)*	*Masoch (after Deleuze)*	*The Order of the Gash*
Juridical form	Institution	Contract	A contract that inaugurates an institution
Mode of discourse	Demonstration	Persuasion and education	Liturgical declaration
Affective tone	Apathy	Coldness	Ceremonial calm
Temporality	Accumulation, acceleration	Suspense, waiting	The instant made eternal
Relation to law	Irony: law exceeded toward a higher principle	Humour: law obeyed to absurdity	Literalism: law executed to the letter
Governing agency	Superego	Idealized ego; the oral mother	The Order: an impersonal rule
Figure of woman	The libertine (Juliette)	The cold torturess educated by her victim	The sexually indeterminate celebrant

3.5 *Limit and Transgression: The Hand-Held Limit*

For Georges Bataille, human beings are discontinuous, each enclosed in an individual existence, and eroticism is the movement by which discontinuous beings seek continuity, the continuity that death alone com-

pletes. Hence his celebrated formula in *L'Érotisme* (1957), that eroticism is *l'approbation de la vie jusque dans la mort*. Transgression, for Bataille, does not abolish the interdict; it suspends it without suppressing it, and so completes it. Michel Foucault's "Préface à la transgression" (1963), written in homage to Bataille, generalized the point: limit and transgression stand in a spiral relation, transgression crossing a line that closes behind it, affirming limited being rather than negating it, illuminating the limit as lightning gives the night its density. After the death of God, Foucault argued, transgression occupies the place once held by the sacred, and sexuality is where modern subjects encounter the limit.

The Configuration is the limit made object. It is a limit one can purchase, carry, turn in the hands, and solve; its lid closes behind the transgressor, as Foucault's spiral requires. It is the hand-held limit, and its portability is philosophically consequential, for a limit that circulates as an object can be bought, sold, gifted, and inherited (Chapter Nine). Threshold, automaton, toy, contract, limit: the Configuration is all of these at once, and their unity is the paradox with which this thesis began. It is an ordered device whose completion is an opening. The next chapter turns from the device to the institution it serves.



Chapter Four

The Order of the Gash

Cenobitic Monasticism and Apollo's Knife

4.1 Koinos Bios: The Monastery and the Bell
4.2 The Ascetic Ideal Inverted
4.3 Iconographies of the Pierced
4.4 The Numinous without Morals
4.5 Acéphale: The Community of the Wound
4.6 Apollo's Knife: Marsyas and Dante
4.7 The Cartesian Cenobite and Kafka's Harrow

4.1 *Koinos Bios: The Monastery and the Bell*

The word *cenobite* derives from the Greek *koinobion*, from *koinos* (common) and *bios* (life). It designates the communal form of monasticism associated with Pachomius (c. 292–348), whose foundations at Tabennisi in Upper Egypt organized ascetics under a shared rule, in deliberate contrast to the solitary, anchoritic life exemplified by Anthony. Barker's choice of term is therefore exact rather than ornamental: the Order is not a horde of demons but a community under a rule. The Rule of Benedict (c. 530), the charter of Western cenobitism, prescribes that at the sounding of the signal for the Divine Office the monk must abandon whatever is in his hands, for *nihil operi Dei praeponatur*, "let nothing be preferred to the Work of God" (RB 43). The novella's first sentence stages the precise inversion of this precept. Frank, absorbed in his own work, fails to hear the bell; he prefers his *opus* to the *Opus Dei*. The bell summons him nonetheless, and he is received into the community whose Office it announces.

The monastic analogy extends through every element of the Cenobitic appearance. The habit is rendered in leather; the tonsure becomes the shaved and incised scalp; the vows are transfigured. Obedience becomes submission to the law of the box, poverty becomes the dispossession of the skin, and chastity becomes the sexual indeterminacy that the novella insists upon. The novella's designation of the Cenobites as theologians of the Order completes the picture: they are not merely practitioners but doctors of a doctrine. Frank's passage is accordingly from anchorite to cenobite. Before the box, he is a hermit of pleasure, sealed in a solitary room; after it, he belongs to a common life of suffering. The word *Order*, finally, carries both of its senses at once: a religious community, and a principle of arrangement.

4.2 *The Ascetic Ideal Inverted*

The Third Essay of Nietzsche's *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887) asks what ascetic ideals mean, and answers that they give suffering a meaning. The ascetic priest is a physician who wounds in order to heal, who redirects the sufferer's ressentiment inward, and whose triumph rests

on a single anthropological fact: humanity would rather will nothingness than not will at all (*lieber will noch der Mensch das Nichts wollen, als nicht wollen*). The Cenobites are ascetic priests, and the lead Cenobite's eventual title, the Hell Priest, makes the identification explicit. Their ideal, however, is shorn of the deferral that defined Christian asceticism. Suffering is not redeemed by a later beatitude; suffering is the beatitude. The Cenobitic ideal is the ascetic ideal with its other world removed and its intensity retained.

The Cenobites' doctrine, moreover, is Nietzsche's own. In the "Nachtwandler-Lied" of *Also sprach Zarathustra* (Part IV), Zarathustra teaches that whoever has said yes to a single joy has said yes to all woe, because all things are *verkettet, verfädelt, verliebt*, chained, entwined, and in love, and that *alle Lust will Ewigkeit*, all joy wants eternity. The indivisibility of pleasure and pain that the Cenobites proclaim is Zarathustra's entanglement of *Lust* and *Weh*. The irony is profound. The Cenobites preach Dionysian affirmation in the form Nietzsche most despised, a priesthood; they hold the doctrine of the drunken song and the office of the ascetic priest at once. Their doctrine is Nietzschean; their institution is the thing Nietzsche wrote against.

4.3 *Iconographies of the Pierced*

Barker has named Catholic devotional imagery among the Cenobites' sources, and the Catholic visual archive already possessed a complete iconography of suffering from which the difference between pleasure and pain had been effaced. Saint Sebastian, his body studded with arrows, had by the twentieth century become an emblem of homoerotic devotion, from Mishima's youthful fixation to Derek Jarman's *Sebastiane* (1976); his arrows return as the Cenobite's pins. Saint Lawrence, roasted on a gridiron, supplies the grid. Saint Bartholomew, flayed alive, appears in Michelangelo's *Last Judgement* holding his own skin, whose sagging face has long been read as the painter's self-portrait; he anticipates Frank's skinless regeneration. The Sacred Heart, propagated after Margaret Mary Alacoque's visions of 1673–75, depicts a heart encircled by thorns, pierced, and aflame; it is the iconographic referent of the

novella's title. The crown of thorns, generalized from a circlet into a coordinate system, becomes the lead Cenobite's head.

The mystical literature supplied the phenomenology. Julian of Norwich, in the first of her *Revelations of Divine Love*, saw red blood trickle down from under the garland of thorns, hot, fresh, and plentiful, and drew from the vision not horror but an overwhelming assurance of love. Teresa of Ávila, in the twenty-ninth chapter of her *Vida*, describes an angel who drove a golden spear tipped with fire into her heart, causing a pain so great that she moaned aloud and a sweetness so excessive that she could not wish it gone. Bernini's sculpture of the scene in the Cornaro Chapel (1647–52) became the canonical image of that indistinction, and Lacan, in his twentieth seminar, would cite it as visible evidence of a jouissance beyond the phallic economy. Matthias Grünewald's crucified Christ at Isenheim, painted for an Antonite hospital that treated the burning disease of ergotism and rapturously described by Huysmans, completes the archive: a body whose wounds are the sign of the divine. Barker removes the referent, Christ and God, and keeps the iconography. What remains is a devotional art of the opened body with no one to whom the devotion is addressed.

4.4 *The Numinous without Morals*

Rudolf Otto's *Das Heilige* (1917) defined the holy as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*: a mystery at once overpowering and alluring, the "wholly other" encountered before it has been schematized by ethical concepts. Otto traced the numinous to a crude first stage he called daemonic dread, from which the moralized holiness of the developed religions slowly emerged. Émile Durkheim had already insisted on the ambiguity of the sacred, which comprises the pure and the impure, the beneficent and the malefic, as two forms of a single force; Roger Caillois distinguished a sacred of respect from a sacred of transgression; and the Latin *sacer* means both consecrated and accursed, an ambivalence Giorgio Agamben would make the basis of his political theory.

The Cenobites' self-description, demons to some and angels to others, is a precise statement of the pre-moral numinous. It does not say

that the Cenobites are evil disguised as good, nor good misunderstood as evil. It says that the moral sign belongs to the observer, while the numinous force belongs to them. They are the holy before its moral schematization, the holy as Otto described it, minus Otto's Lutheran confidence that schematization would follow.

4.5 *Acéphale: The Community of the Wound*

In 1936 Bataille founded both a review and a secret society under the name *Acéphale*. André Masson's emblem depicts a headless man holding a flaming heart in one hand and a dagger in the other, his entrails coiled into a labyrinth: the burning heart, the blade, and the labyrinth, the three icons of the Hellraiser mythos, assembled half a century earlier. Through the Collège de Sociologie (1937–39), Bataille, Caillois, and Michel Leiris pursued a sociology of the sacred grounded in expenditure, sacrifice, and communal ecstasy. In 1983, the year Barker's *Books of Blood* were being prepared for publication, Maurice Blanchot's *La Communauté inavouable* and Jean-Luc Nancy's essay on the inoperative community reopened Bataille's question: what is a community not founded on fusion or shared identity but on shared exposure to finitude? Bataille's answer had been communication through laceration, the *déchirure* by which closed beings are opened to one another. The Order of the Gash is Acéphale realized: a community constituted by the wound, whose members communicate through the opening of their bodies, and whose emblem, like Masson's, is a heart.

4.6 *Apollo's Knife: Marsyas and Dante*

Nietzsche's *Die Geburt der Tragödie* (1872) opposed Apollo, god of form, measure, and the *principium individuationis*, to Dionysus, god of intoxication and of the individual's dissolution into primordial unity. A conventional reading would align the Cenobites with Dionysus. The myth of Marsyas complicates that alignment decisively. The satyr, a Dionysian piper, challenged Apollo to a contest of music, lost, and was flayed alive by the god. Ovid's *Metamorphoses* (VI.382–400) gives him a cry that could serve as the epigraph of this thesis, *quid me mihi detrahis?*,

"why do you tear me from myself?", and then a line that could serve as its definition of the Cenobite: *nec quicquam nisi vulnus erat*, "he was nothing but a wound." Herodotus (7.26) reports that the skin was hung at Celaenae; Titian's late *Flaying of Marsyas* gave the scene its most harrowing painterly form.

Dante supplies the decisive turn. Invoking Apollo at the opening of the *Paradiso* (I.19–21), he asks the god to enter his breast and breathe there *sì come quando Marsïa traesti / de la vagina de le membra sue*, "as when you drew Marsyas from the sheath of his limbs." The supreme poem of the Christian West requests, as the condition of its final ascent, to be flayed by the god of order; and the word Dante chooses for the skin from which the satyr is drawn is *vagina*, sheath. The Order of the Gash is here in nuce: inspiration as flaying, divine form entering through the wound, the skin as the sheath from which the self is drawn. In Nietzsche's scheme, Apollonian illusion veils the Dionysian abyss and so makes it bearable. In the Marsyan scheme that Barker's Order inherits, the Apollonian does not veil the Dionysian; it carves itself into Dionysian flesh. This is the meaning of *lacerative order*.

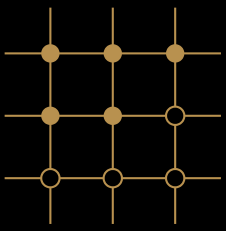
4.7 *The Cartesian Cenobite and Kafka's Harrow*

The lead Cenobite's head is incised with a grid, and at each intersection a pin is driven home; the novella specifies jewelled pins driven to the bone. A grid is a coordinate system, the device by which Descartes's *La Géométrie* (1637) made extension addressable, every point specified by an ordered pair. The Cenobite's head is *res extensa* rendered literally as mapped extension, each pin marking an address. Above it, the voice, measured, articulate, philosophical, is *res cogitans* undisturbed. The figure is at once the monument of Cartesian dualism and its parody: a serene mind presiding over a body that has become pure geometry.

Kafka's "In der Strafkolonie" (1919) supplies the counter-image. Its apparatus inscribes the condemned man's sentence into his flesh with the needles of a Harrow over twelve hours; around the sixth hour, the officer claims, understanding dawns even on the dullest, who deciphers the sentence with his wounds. When the old order collapses,

the officer places himself in the machine, which malfunctions and kills him without the promised transfiguration; his dead face shows no trace of redemption, the great iron spike driven through his forehead. The Cenobite is the Harrow's success: the sentence fully inscribed, the transfiguration accomplished, the pins in the skull not a sign of failure but of completion. Kafka and Barker answer the same question, whether inscription in the flesh can produce understanding. Kafka answers no. Barker answers yes, and makes the yes the horror.

The Order of the Gash is thus a monastery, an ascetic ideal, an iconography, a numinous, a community, and an aesthetic of Apollonian laceration. Its unifying principle is that the wound is ordered and the order is a wound.



Chapter Five

Flesh, Skin, and the Abject

The House as Body

5.1 Regeneration: Osiris, Zagreus, Frankenstein
5.2 Skins: Jacob, Xipe Totec, the Skin-Ego
5.3 Julia: Lilith, Juliette, Bovary
5.4 Kirsty: Justine Re-dealt and the Harrowing
5.5 Abjection and the Unhomely
5.6 Queer Flesh and the Epidemic Hour

5.1 *Regeneration: Osiris, Zagreus, Frankenstein*

The film's second movement begins with a domestic accident of liturgical precision. Larry, hauling a mattress up the stairs, gashes his hand on a protruding nail, and his blood falls on the boards of the upstairs room where Frank was torn apart. The nail and the bed, the instrument of crucifixion and the furniture of marriage, conjoin at the threshold of the regeneration. What follows, as organs, vessels, and a pulsing heart reassemble out of the floor, reverses decomposition frame by frame and constitutes the mythos's central image of the body.

The image is a mythologem. In Plutarch's *De Iside et Osiride*, Osiris is dismembered by his brother Set and his fragments scattered; Isis gathers them, fails to recover the phallus, which fish have eaten, and fashions a substitute. *Hellraiser* transposes the structure with a series of inversions. The transgressive brother, not the righteous one, is the dismembered god; Julia, a perverse Isis, gathers not his fragments but the blood of other men to reconstitute him; and the regenerated Frank remains through most of the film a skinless body whose erotic union with Julia is perpetually deferred, an assemblage of organs that has not yet become a body. When Frank kills Larry and usurps his place, the roles invert again, and the dismembered god becomes Set. The Orphic myth of Zagreus offers a second template: the infant Dionysus is torn apart and devoured by the Titans, but Athena saves his heart, from which the god is reborn. The heart is the organ that survives dismemberment, and it is a heart that the novella's title binds to Hell. Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) supplies the modern, Promethean form of the same mythologem: a body assembled from the dead by a man who will not accept the limit. The name, as Chapter One noted, is already in Frank's. What distinguishes Barker's version is that the reassembly is predatory. Julia's hammer administers a perverse Eucharist in which the bodies of strangers are given so that Frank's body may be made whole.

5.2 *Skins: Jacob, Xipe Totec, the Skin-Ego*

The climax turns on a borrowed skin. Frank, having killed Larry, wears his flayed skin to deceive Kirsty, and the scene rewrites Genesis 27 with exactness. There, at Rebekah's instigation, Jacob covers his hands and the smooth of his neck with the skins of kids so as to pass for his hairy brother before their blind father, and Isaac, touching him, utters the formula of misrecognition: "The voice is Jacob's voice, but the hands are the hands of Esau." Isaac is deceived and gives the blessing. Kirsty is not deceived. Her recognition of the brother beneath the father's skin is the film's ethical climax, and Chapter Eight will read it through Levinas.

Comparative religion supplies a ritual counterpart. The Mexica deity Xipe Totec, "Our Lord the Flayed One," presided over the festival of Tlacaxipehualiztli, the "flaying of men," during which priests wore the skins of sacrificial victims for some twenty days; the dead skin figured the husk from which the new growth of spring emerges. Frank's renewal through another man's skin is a Xipe rite in a London house. Herodotus's report of Marsyas's skin hanging at Celaenae (Chapter Four) belongs to the same archive of skins displayed as trophies of a transfiguring violence.

Two theorists frame the psychic and cultural stakes. Didier Anzieu's *Le Moi-peau* (1985), published within a year of the novella, conceived the skin-ego as the psychic envelope that contains, protects, and receives inscriptions; a psyche without a skin-ego is a psyche without boundary. Frank skinless is an ego without envelope; Frank in Larry's skin is an ego wearing a borrowed one. Jack Halberstam's *Skin Shows* (1995) argued that the Gothic monster is a technology for making skin the site of identity, and traced the motif to Thomas Harris's Buffalo Bill (1988), who sews himself a suit of women's skins, and behind him to Leatherface and to Ed Gein. In those texts, skin-wearing figures a fantasy of identity transfer. In *Hellraiser*, it figures that fantasy's failure. The skin does not carry the self, which is why the daughter can see through it.

5.3 *Julia: Lilith, Juliette, Bovary*

Julia is the film's most active desiring subject and, on a strong reading, its true protagonist; Clare Higgins's performance makes her the only figure whose desire is directed at a person rather than at intensity or knowledge. Her flashback, in which Frank possesses her upon the linen of her own wedding dress, locates the origin of her crime in a memory of transgression that marriage has not been able to replace. Her genealogy is crowded. She is Lilith, who in medieval Jewish lore refused subordination as Adam's first wife and became a night spirit who seduces and destroys men; Julia lures men home to die. She is Juliette, the Sadean sister who prospers through vice, and whom Angela Carter's *The Sadeian Woman* (1979) read as the woman who purchases agency by adopting a masculine predation. She is Barbara Creed's *femme castratrice*, wielding the hammer. And she is Emma Bovary, bored within bourgeois marriage and enthralled by the memory of a lover, turned toward the crimes of Clytemnestra.

Julia's fate refuses Sade's moral economy. Juliette prospers; Julia dies, consumed by the man she restored as she had sacrificed others to him. Yet Barker does not simply invert Sade into a conventional morality, for *Hellbound* returns Julia as a skinless sovereign of the labyrinth, enthroned in Hell. Juliette prospers after all, but only on the other side of the Configuration.

5.4 *Kirsty: Justine Re-dealt and the Harrowing*

If Julia is Juliette, Kirsty is Justine re-dealt. Sade's Justine is virtue as perpetual victimhood: her goodness guarantees her suffering, and the 1791 version ends with her death by lightning, a sardonic parody of providence. Kirsty is virtuous but not passive. She investigates, steals the box, solves it, bargains with its Order, and survives. Hers is virtue armed with contract. Carol Clover's Final Girl, the watchful, resourceful, sexually reticent survivor through whom the audience experiences both terror and triumph, describes her imperfectly, for her last antagonist is not a killer but an institution, and she defeats it not by violence but by negotiation and recognition.

Hellbound sends her into Hell to rescue a father she believes is calling to her, a call that proves to be Frank's ruse. The descent repeats the Harrowing of Hell, the tradition, grounded in 1 Peter 3:19 and elaborated in the apocryphal Gospel of Nicodemus, of Christ's descent between death and resurrection to free the righteous dead, and it repeats Orpheus's descent for Eurydice. The name Kirsty, from Christina, makes the first analogy audible. Kirsty is, above all, the one figure in the mythos who can both solve and un-solve the box, who masters the Configuration in both directions. She is the agent of the Lament.

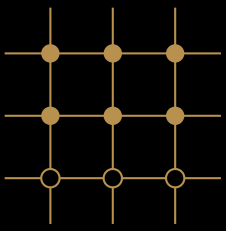
5.5 *Abjection and the Unhomely*

Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) defined the abject as that which is neither subject nor object, which disturbs identity, system, and order, and which the subject must expel in order to constitute itself; the corpse is its supreme instance, and its prototype is the infant's violent separation from the maternal body. Frank skinless is abjection incarnate, a living corpse whose wet and glistening exposure both repels and fascinates Julia. He is, moreover, born from the floor, a parturition without a mother in which the house itself becomes the womb. Freud's essay on the uncanny (1919) traced how *heimlich*, the homely and familiar, becomes *unheimlich*, the uncanny, through the return of what was repressed; nothing could literalize the formula better than a brother returning from beneath the floorboards of the family house.

Gaston Bachelard's *La Poétique de l'espace* (1958) mapped the house vertically: the attic is the zone of rationality and clarity, the cellar the zone of the irrational and the subterranean. *Hellraiser* inverts the map. The abyss is upstairs; the room of light and reason opens onto Hell. The inversion is not incidental but follows from lacerative order itself, in which the highest point of rational arrangement is the place of the wound. Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) read the confined Bertha Mason as the double of the Victorian heroine, the repository of her suppressed rage and desire. Frank is the madman in the attic, Julia's double and her secret self, fed on what she cannot permit herself to be in the rooms below.

5.6 *Queer Flesh and the Epidemic Hour*

Benshoff and others have read the Cenobites' leather, harness, and piercing as an importation of gay sadomasochistic iconography into the mainstream horror film, made by an author who was openly gay, at the height of an epidemic that had made gay male desire the object of public terror. The reading is indispensable but should not be reduced to allegory. The Cenobites are not a disease; they are an Order. What *Hellraiser* refuses is the period's dominant moral equation, in which desire produces punishment, for it makes the so-called punishment the very object of desire. Leo Bersani's "Is the Rectum a Grave?" (1987), published in the year of the film, drew on Jean Laplanche to argue that sexuality is constitutively self-shattering, that its value lies in the undoing of the self's sovereign coherence, and that pastoral or redemptive accounts of sex betray it. The Cenobitic laceration is self-shattering made literal. Foucault's late interviews, likewise, described sadomasochistic practice as the creation of new possibilities of pleasure through the eroticization of strategic relations and the use of bodies beyond genital organization. The Order's sexual indeterminacy is the figure of such a pleasure: utopian in its release from the genital economy, dystopian in the institution that administers it.



Chapter Six

Comparative Infernology

Hellraiser *among the Hells*

6.1 Dante: Contrapasso and the Love That Built Hell

6.2 Marlowe, Milton, Goethe: Hell as Condition and the Forbidden Moment

6.3 The Gothic Monastery: Lewis and Maturin

6.4 Machen and Lovecraft: Sin as Siege and Cosmic Intimacy

6.5 The Aesthetics of the Supplice: Sade, Mirbeau, Lautréamont, Pasolini, Orwell

6.6 The Wound as Interface: Cronenberg, Ballard, Laugier, and Barker's Later Mythology

6.7 Beyond the West: Chinnamasta and the Left-Hand Path

The distinctiveness of Barker's Hell emerges only against the record of its predecessors. The comparison below anticipates the chapter's argument: every major literary Hell assigns desire a fate and Hell a sovereign; Barker's alone fulfils desire absolutely and replaces the sovereign with an Order.

Text	*Where Hell is*	*Governing principle*	*Fate of desire*	*Sovereign*
Dante, *Inferno*	The earth's interior; a moral cosmos	Contrapasso under divine justice and love	Fixed eternally in the form of its sin	God; Lucifer frozen at the centre
Marlowe, *Doctor Faustus*	Carried within the damned	The contract	Purchased, then foreclosed	Lucifer, through Mephistopheles
Milton, *Paradise Lost*	Mind and place at once	Self-sovereignty	Perverted into pride	Satan, self-proclaimed
Goethe, *Faust I*	The arrested moment	A wager against satisfaction	Forbidden to rest	Mephistopheles as wagering agent
Kafka, *In der Strafkolonie*	An apparatus	Inscription of the sentence	Irrelevant to the law	A dead Commandant
Lovecraft, weird tales	The cosmos outside	Indifference	Insignificant	None, or blind forces
Barker, *Hellraiser*	Beyond a threshold opened by a device	Sign-annihilation	Fulfilled absolutely	The Order; Leviathan in *Hellbound*

6.1 *Dante: Contrapasso and the Love That Built Hell*

The inscription over Dante's gate (*Inferno* III.4–6) declares that Hell was made by justice, divine power, supreme wisdom, and *'l primo amore*, primal love. Dante's is the most rigorously ordered Hell in literature, an engineered funnel of circles, rings, and the ten concentric ditches of Malebolge, and at its nadir Lucifer is not burning but frozen in the ice of Cocytus. Two features bear directly on Barker. The first is that Hell's founding principle is declared, in Hell's own voice, to be love: no closer precedent exists for an infernal order that names itself angelic to some. The second is the *contrapasso*, the law by which punishment reproduces the form of the sin, named by Bertran de Born as he

carries his severed head like a lantern (XXVIII.142). Paolo and Francesca, swept in life by passion, are swept forever by a whirlwind (V); their adulterous pairing is the template of Julia and Frank.

The Cenobitic gift is the purest contrapasso in literature. Frank's punishment is not analogous to his desire; it is identical to it. He receives exactly what he sought. What Barker removes is Dante's justice: the contrapasso survives without a judge, as a correspondence between desire and fate stripped of moral sign. This is post-moral contrapasso, and it explains why the Cenobites need no tribunal. The identity of crime and consequence is executed by the Configuration itself.

6.2 *Marlowe, Milton, Goethe: Hell as Condition and the Forbidden Moment*

Asked how he comes to be out of Hell, Marlowe's Mephistopheles replies, "Why, this is hell, nor am I out of it." Hell is a condition carried, not a place visited. Milton's Satan radicalizes the claim into a boast, "The mind is its own place, and in itself / Can make a Heav'n of Hell, a Hell of Heav'n" (*Paradise Lost* I.254–55), and then into a confession, "Which way I fly is Hell; myself am Hell" (IV.75). The Cenobites are Marlovian, for they carry their region with them as explorers, but they are decisively anti-Miltonic. Satan's boast presupposes that the sovereign mind assigns the sign; his tragedy in Book IV is the discovery that he cannot re-assign it. The Cenobites have no such tragedy, because they have abolished the sign the mind would assign. Milton's Satan is a failed re-signer; the Cenobites are sign-annihilators.

Goethe's *Faust* (1808) supplies the temporal form of the problem. Faust stakes his soul on a single condition: he will be lost if he ever says to the passing moment, *Verweile doch! du bist so schön!*, "Stay, you are so beautiful." Faustian striving is defined as perpetual dissatisfaction, a desire that may never rest in any instant. Frank lives Faust's wager without its redemption; no pleasure has ever made him say *verweile doch*. The Configuration grants him, at last, a moment that stays: the instant made eternal, the infernal fulfilment of Zarathustra's *alle Lust will Ewigkeit*. The box gives what Faust forbade himself.

6.3 *The Gothic Monastery: Lewis and Maturin*

Matthew Lewis's *The Monk* (1796) traces the fall of Ambrosio, a revered abbot seduced by a demon in the guise of a devoted novice, through lust, rape, and murder in the convent's sepulchres, to a bargain with Lucifer that ends with his body broken on the rocks. Charles Maturin's *Melmoth the Wanderer* (1820) follows a man who sold his soul for extended life and wanders the world seeking someone who will take his bargain from him, through convents and inquisitorial prisons depicted as theatres of cruelty. The Gothic monastery is a site of hypocrisy: the habit conceals the flesh, and Protestant anticlericalism exposes the gap. Barker inherits the Gothic monastery and closes the gap. The Cenobites are not hypocrites; their lust is their vow, and the habit is the flesh. Melmoth's transferable bargain, meanwhile, anticipates the Configuration's circulation from owner to owner.

6.4 *Machen and Lovecraft: Sin as Siege and Cosmic Intimacy*

The prologue to Arthur Machen's "The White People" (1904) contains the most exact theory of Frank's transgression in English letters. Machen's recluse Ambrose distinguishes sin from the mere violation of social rules: true sin, he argues, is as rare as true sanctity, and consists in an attempt to enter another and higher sphere by forbidden means, to seize by illicit force the ecstasy and knowledge proper to angels. Frank is Machen's sinner; the box is the forbidden means; the Order is the sphere. *The Great God Pan* (1894) supplies the surgical version, in which Dr Raymond cuts into a young woman's brain so that she may see the god Pan, with catastrophic consequences: perception is opened by a cut, and reality, revealed, destroys its witness.

H. P. Lovecraft's "From Beyond" (written 1920) imagines a resonator that awakens dormant sense organs and reveals the creatures that have always surrounded us; "The Dreams in the Witch House" (1933) makes non-Euclidean angles into portals, a geometry that anticipates the box. Yet Lovecraft's cosmic horror is a horror of insignificance. Its cosmos is indifferent, and humanity is a negligible accident within it. Barker reverses the premise. The Cenobites are intensely interested in

the human, connoisseurs of its sensorium; their horror is the horror of significance, of being attended to with infinite and unwanted care. Against cosmic indifference, Barker proposes cosmic intimacy. The elsewhere is not indifferent; it is attentive. This is perhaps his most consequential departure from the Anglo-American weird tradition.

6.5 *The Aesthetics of the Supplice: Sade, Mirbeau, Lautréamont, Pasolini, Orwell*

Sade's château of Silling is governed by regulations, timetables, and a hierarchy of storytellers: a bureaucracy of pleasure. Octave Mirbeau's *Le Jardin des supplices* (1899) leads its narrator, guided by the Englishwoman Clara, through a Chinese garden where torture is practised as a fine art among flowers, the executioner an aesthete; its orientalist frame anticipates the film's bazaar. Lautréamont's *Les Chants de Maldoror* (1868–69) made cruelty lyrical and bequeathed to Surrealism its formula of beauty, the chance meeting of a sewing machine and an umbrella on a dissecting table; the dissecting table is the altar of the modern marvellous, and Barker's surrealist inheritance passes through it. Pasolini's *Salò* (1975) transposed Sade into the last redoubt of Italian Fascism and ends with tortures watched through binoculars from a window, distance itself made an instrument of enjoyment. Orwell's O'Brien, the articulate priest of power in *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949), and Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor before him, complete the lineage of the eloquent torturer, which culminates in the Hell Priest's liturgical calm.

6.6 *The Wound as Interface: Cronenberg, Ballard, Laugier, and Barker's Later Mythology*

In David Cronenberg's *Videodrome* (1983), a vaginal slit opens in Max Renn's abdomen to receive videocassettes: the wound becomes an interface between technology and flesh, the port of the "new flesh." In J. G. Ballard's *Crash* (1973), Vaughan eroticizes the wounds of automobile collisions as new sexual apertures, so that the scar becomes an organ. Pascal Laugier's *Martyrs* (2008) depicts a secret society that tortures

young women in pursuit of a martyr whose flayed body might testify to what lies beyond death; its final ecstatic gaze descends from the photographs of a Chinese execution by slicing that Bataille meditated upon in *Les Larmes d'Éros* (1961), and the line between them passes through the Cenobites. Paul W. S. Anderson's *Event Horizon* (1997), whose starship returns from a dimension of chaos and pain, is an open homage. Neil Gaiman's *The Sandman: Season of Mists* (1990–91), in which Lucifer abdicates and leaves Hell vacant, treats Hell as an institution with a key.

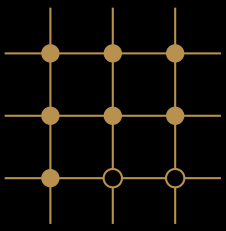
Barker's own later mythology clarifies what *Hellraiser* achieved. In *Imajica* (1991), the god Hapexamendios is revealed as a patriarchal geometer who annihilated the goddesses, and love is embodied in the Pie 'oh' pah, a mystif of fluid gender. Order and fluidity are there separated and moralized: rigid order is tyranny, fluid desire is redemption. In *The Great and Secret Show* (1989), the dream-sea Quiddity, reached only at a few thresholds of a life, makes eros a route to the metaphysical. Barker's oeuvre oscillates between configurations in which the Order and the Gash are opposed, as in *Imajica*, and the configuration in which they are fused, which is *Hellraiser*'s alone.

6.7 *Beyond the West: Chinnamasta and the Left-Hand Path*

Comparative religion offers traditions in which the transgressive and the ascetic are fused in practice. Chinnamasta, one of the ten Mahavidyas of Hindu Tantra, is depicted holding her own severed head, which drinks one of the streams of blood that her attendants share, while she stands upon the copulating deities Kama and Rati: sexuality, death, self-sacrifice, and nourishment form a single image. The Tantric left-hand path employs the five ritually transgressive substances and acts, culminating in sexual union, as instruments of liberation; Aghori ascetics meditate among the ashes of cremation grounds. These are religious systems in which the sign of the impure is suspended for the sake of release.

A methodological caution is necessary. The film's bazaar reproduces what Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978) analysed as the West's projec-

tion of forbidden sensuality onto the East, and comparison must not repeat that gesture. The point of comparison is structural, not exotic: several traditions have conceived a sacred in which the sign of experience is suspended. Some suspend it through excess; others, as the next chapter shows, through extinction.



Chapter Seven

The Absolute Value of the Wound

Toward a Lacerative Metaphysics

7.1 The Formal Model: Valence, Magnitude, and the Operator C

7.2 Two Limits: The Nirvanic Zero and the Cenobitic Infinite

7.3 Sign-Invariance and Proper Intensity

7.4 Lacerative Order: The Absolute as Absolute Value

7.5 Hyperincarnation against Excarnation

7.6 Infernal Legalism: Leviathan, Self-Ownership, and R v Brown

7.7 The Thesis Stated

The preceding chapters assembled the materials; this chapter states the thesis in formal terms. The formalization is heuristic. It does not claim that affect is a real number, only that the doctrines of the mythos possess the structure of a well-understood operation, and that recognizing the structure clarifies what the mythos otherwise leaves mystified.

7.1 *The Formal Model: Valence, Magnitude, and the Operator C*

Let any experience e be represented as a signed magnitude. Its sign is its valence: pleasure positive, pain negative, and, within a moral frame, good positive and evil negative. Its absolute value is its intensity. Kant had already separated the two dimensions. In the "Anticipations of Perception" of the *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*, every sensation possesses an intensive magnitude, a degree, which can diminish continuously toward zero independently of the sensation's quality. Hedonic axiology, from Epicurus through Bentham to Freud's pleasure principle, orders experiences by the signed quantity: more pleasure is better, more pain worse. Cenobitic axiology orders them by magnitude alone. The Configuration is the operator that performs the transition:

$$C\colon \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}, \qquad C(e) = |e| \tag{7.1}$$

Three properties follow, and each corresponds to a doctrine of the mythos:

$$\begin{aligned} C(e) &= C(-e) \\ C(C(e)) &= C(e) \\ \nexists g\colon g(C(e)) &= e \quad \textit{for all } e \end{aligned} \tag{7.2}$$

The first is non-injectivity: pleasure and pain of equal intensity are mapped to the same value. This is the doctrine of indivisibility. The second is idempotence: once the sign is annihilated, further application changes nothing. There is no Hell beyond Hell, and initiation is complete in a single act, which is why the box is solved once, why its effect is total, and why the sequels' escalations (further boxes, further configurations, further Hells) are formally redundant. The third is non-in-

vertibility: no function can recover e from its absolute value, because the information carried by the sign has been destroyed. There is no computational road back from the Cenobitic state. Return requires a supplement that is not a computation but a decision, the act this thesis calls re-signation (Chapter Eight).

The model also isolates what the Cenobites are not. The satanist's operation is negation, $e \mapsto -e$: the Black Mass reverses values but preserves the structure of valuation, and is therefore a re-signing, not an annihilation. The absolute value is the only elementary operation that abolishes the sign rather than reversing it. This is why the Cenobites are not devils in the theological sense, and why every attempt to make them devils has diminished them.

The model further specifies the sense in which the Cenobites stand beyond the pleasure principle. In Freud's economic model, pleasure corresponds to the decrease of excitation and unpleasure to its increase; the hedonic sign is attached not to the level of tension but to the direction of its change. Hedonic value, in Freud, is the sign of a derivative. The Cenobites value the level, not the derivative; they are indifferent to whether tension rises or falls and measure only its magnitude. They are therefore not agents of the death drive, which in *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* seeks the reduction of tension to zero, but agents of a third tendency, toward unbounded tension, which Lacan named *jouissance*: the excess beyond homeostasis, the enjoyment that hurts.

7.2 *Two Limits: The Nirvanic Zero and the Cenobitic Infinite*

Whoever wishes to escape the tyranny of the hedonic sign has two routes. Let $\delta(e)$ denote an experiencer's capacity to discriminate the sign of an experience of a given magnitude. That capacity vanishes at both extremities of the scale:

$$\lim_{|e| \to 0} \delta(e) = 0 = \lim_{|e| \to \infty} \delta(e) \tag{7.3}$$

At zero, nothing remains to be discriminated; at saturation, discrimination collapses. The first route is extinction. Freud, borrowing the phrase from Barbara Low, called it the Nirvana principle, the tendency toward

the reduction of excitation to zero; Schopenhauer's denial of the will and the quietisms of East and West follow it. (Buddhist *nirvāṇa* is not reducible to Freud's appropriation: it designates the cessation of craving rather than a thermodynamic zero, and the Buddhist analysis of feeling into pleasant, painful, and neutral already relativizes the hedonic sign. Freud's usage is cited for its structural role in Western thought, not as an account of Buddhist doctrine.) The second route is excess: Bataille's inner experience, the transverberations of the mystics, the Cenobites.

The two routes are mirror images. The first abolishes the sign by abolishing magnitude; the second abolishes it by maximizing magnitude. The mystical traditions oscillate between them, from Meister Eckhart's *Gelassenheit* at the zero to Teresa's spear at the infinite. *Hellraiser* is the most rigorous modern exploration of the infinite route, and its horror lies in the discovery that the two limits coincide in one respect: both annihilate the person who once discriminated. Frank, at the end, is neither pleased nor pained. He is gone, distributed across the hooks of a sign-less magnitude.

7.3 *Sign-Invariance and Proper Intensity*

The Cenobites' self-description, demons to some and angels to others, can now be read as an invariance principle. Valence is frame-dependent: it changes with the observer's moral frame. Magnitude is invariant: it is the same in every frame. Physics distinguishes frame-dependent quantities, such as coordinate time, from invariants, such as proper time. By analogy, this thesis calls the frame-independent magnitude of an experience its *proper intensity*:

$$\sigma_O(e) \neq \sigma_{O'}(e) \quad \textit{whereas} \quad |e|_O = |e|_{O'} \tag{7.4}$$

Nietzsche anticipated the principle in *Jenseits von Gut und Böse* §108: *Es gibt gar keine moralischen Phänomene, sondern nur eine moralische Ausdeutung von Phänomenen*, there are no moral phenomena, only a moral interpretation of phenomena. Otto's numinous (Chapter Four) is proper intensity encountered before moral interpretation. The

Cenobites are the invariant; angels and demons are its coordinate representations in different frames. Their horror is the horror of an invariant. They cannot be argued with, because argument operates on interpretation, and they subsist beneath it.

7.4 *Lacerative Order: The Absolute as Absolute Value*

The formalization explains how the Cenobites can be at once ecstatic and orderly. The operator C is perfectly lawful. The annihilation of sign is not chaos but a rule. Western thought has generally coupled order with the sign (law distinguishes the permitted from the forbidden, reason the true from the false) and coupled the abolition of sign with chaos. Hegel's preface to the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) gave the coupling its most famous form when he mocked Schelling's Absolute, conceived as the absolute indifference of subject and object, as the night in which, as the saying goes, all cows are black. Indifference, for Hegel, was darkness.

Hellraiser decouples the terms. Sign-annihilation is executed with geometric rigour, and the night of indifference is lit by a grid. Hence lacerative order: the identity of the highest order and the deepest wound. Its emblem is the pin at the intersection of the grid, at once a coordinate and a puncture. The comparison with the precursors is exact. In Sade, order serves crime: the regulations of Silling exist for the sake of the orgy. In Kafka, the wound serves the sentence: inscription exists for the sake of punishment. In the monastic Rule, mortification serves obedience. In each case one term instrumentalizes the other. In *Hellraiser*, neither is the means of the other; they are the same act. To solve the box is to open the self. The pun in this thesis's title is therefore not idle. The Absolute of German Idealism, the unconditioned point of indifference, returns in Barker as the absolute value: an indifference between pleasure and pain that is neither dark nor chaotic, but luminous, geometric, and administered.

7.5 *Hyperincarnation against Excarnation*

Charles Taylor's *A Secular Age* (2007) describes "excarnation" as the long movement by which Western religious life migrated out of ritual, feast, pilgrimage, and the body into inward belief and moral discipline. Gnostic dualism had long imagined salvation as escape from the flesh. *Hellraiser* proposes the opposite movement, which this thesis names *hyperincarnation*: the sacred encountered not by leaving the flesh but by intensifying embodiment until the flesh becomes the medium of the infinite. The Cenobites are hyperincarnate beings. The doctrine of the Incarnation (*Verbum caro factum est*, John 1:14) and of the resurrection of the flesh is parodied and, in a sense, fulfilled in Frank's regeneration. Jean-Luc Nancy's *Corpus* (1992) argued that the body is not a container of sense but its exposure, its *ex-peau-sition*; the Cenobitic body is maximal exposition, skin opened to the world. Hyperincarnation is, finally, the answer to Taylor's diagnosis. When a culture excarnates its religion, the sacred returns where the body was abandoned: in horror, in pornography, and in what Chapter Eight will call the body genres.

7.6 *Infernal Legalism: Leviathan, Self-Ownership, and R v Brown*

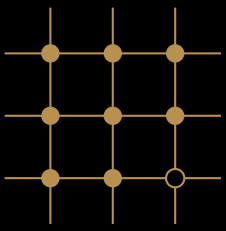
The Order is not lawless; it is hyper-legal. The solving of the box is a performative in J. L. Austin's sense, an act that does what it declares, like a vow or a signature, effective by convention and irrevocable by retraction. The Cenobites keep faith: they honour Kirsty's bargain and enforce its terms. *Hellbound* names the sovereign of their realm Leviathan, and the name summons two archives. The first is the sea monster of Job 41, introduced by a question the Cenobites answer in the affirmative: "Canst thou draw out leviathan with an hook?" The second is Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651), the "mortal god" that guarantees covenants by the terror of its power, born when individuals surrender their rights in exchange for security. Kirsty's bargain is a Hobbesian covenant: she trades another's life for her own security under a sovereign who will enforce the exchange. Yet *Hellbound*'s Leviathan is no decisionist sovereign of the kind Carl Schmitt defined as the one who decides on the exception. It is a rotating figure of pure form that never decides and only

executes. This thesis calls it *geometric sovereignty*: rule without decision, law as shape.

Locke grounded property in self-ownership: every man has a property in his own person (*Second Treatise* §27). The Configuration stages the antinomy latent in that principle. Solving the box is the ultimate exercise of self-ownership, the alienation of one's own person, and it abolishes the self-ownership it exercises. English law confronted the same antinomy in *R v Brown* (1993). The majority held that consent could not license the infliction of actual bodily harm in sadomasochistic encounters; the dissenting Lords Mustill and Slynn defended the claims of privacy and autonomy. The state, in *Brown*, acted as a re-signing machine, re-attaching a negative sign to wounding irrespective of consent. The Order of the Gash is the jurisdiction *Brown* refused: a law in which consent, once given, is absolute and irrevocable. Either consent is sovereign, in which case one may consent to one's own abolition, or the state may override consent, in which case self-ownership is not sovereign. The box is the limit case of liberal contract.

7.7 *The Thesis Stated*

The argument can now be stated whole. *Hellraiser* articulates a lacerative metaphysics whose central operation, the absolute-value operator, abolishes the sign of experience while preserving and maximizing its magnitude. The operation is lawful (lacerative order), embodied (hyperincarnation), juridically binding (infernal legalism), and invariant across moral frames (proper intensity), and it approaches the infinite rather than the nirvanic limit of sign-annihilation. Its scandal is threefold: the infinite that desire seeks exists; it is sign-less; and it is reached by order rather than by chaos. What remains to be shown is what the mythos sets against it.



Chapter Eight

Lacrimae

Body Genres, the Spectator, and the Ethics of Re-signation

8.1 The Interdiction of Tears
8.2 Jesus Wept: The Anti-Lazarus
8.3 The Body Genres: Williams's Triad
8.4 The Spectator as Solver: Horror's Autotheory
8.5 Mourning and Melancholia: Julia's Refusal, Kirsty's Work
8.6 Re-signation: Resignation, the Face, and the Ethics of the Lament

8.1 *The Interdiction of Tears*

When Kirsty weeps before the Cenobites in her hospital room, the lead Cenobite rebukes her: her tears are unwanted, a waste of good suffering. The remark is a theory of tears, and the most philosophically consequential line in the film. Tears are the sign's return. Weeping converts intensity into loss, magnitude into grief, an unsigned quantity into a meaning addressed to another. Tears are the body's lament, the one secretion that is also a sign. The Cenobitic economy therefore forbids them, and it forbids them in the vocabulary of economy: tears waste suffering.

The interdiction has a historical irony that the critical literature has missed. The cenobites of late antiquity made weeping their characteristic act. The Desert Fathers cultivated *penthos*, mourning for sin, and the gift of tears; John Climacus devoted a step of *The Ladder of Divine Ascent* to mourning and coined for it the paradoxical name of joy-making sorrow. Historical cenobitism was a discipline of tears. Barker's Order preserves every element of the monastic life except this one. His Cenobites are cenobites without *penthos*, monks from whom the gift of tears has been excised.

The remark carries a second irony, which Chapter Nine will develop. The Cenobites appear to be agents of what Bataille called the general economy, the economy of unproductive expenditure. Yet in objecting to waste, they reveal themselves as accountants. Suffering, for them, is a resource that tears squander. The Order economizes pain.

8.2 *Jesus Wept: The Anti-Lazarus*

As the hooks claim him, Frank's last words are "Jesus wept": John 11:35, the shortest verse in the English Bible, spoken at the tomb of Lazarus immediately before Christ raises him from the dead. The citation is overdetermined. Frank has himself been raised from the dead, from the floor of a house rather than from a tomb, and at the moment of his final death he cites the verse that precedes the archetypal resurrection. He is the anti-Lazarus, and his words are at once blasphemy and lament, a sneer and a confession. He invokes the one figure in the

Gospels whose tears are divine, at the instant when tears have become impossible for him.

Bataille's last book, *Les Larmes d'Éros* (1961), surveyed images from the caves of Lascaux to the 1905 photographs of a Chinese execution by slicing, in whose victim's face Bataille claimed to discern an ecstatic expression; its title binds tears to eros. The Cenobites sever what Bataille joined. They want eros without tears, ecstasy without lament. Frank's final words restore the tears at the moment eros is consummated, and the box's very name, Lament, carries the tears its Order forbids. Tears are thus the hidden axis of the mythos: forbidden by the Order, invoked by the damned, inscribed in the name of the device.

8.3 *The Body Genres: Williams's Triad*

Linda Williams's "Film Bodies: Gender, Genre, and Excess" (1991) identified three "body genres," pornography, horror, and melodrama, whose excess is measured by the spectator's involuntary mimicry of the body on screen. Williams aligned each with one of the original fantasies described by Laplanche and Pontalis, and with a characteristic temporality.

Body genre (Williams)	*Spectator's bodily response*	*Original fantasy and its time*	*Function in* Hellraiser
Pornography	Sexual arousal	Seduction: "on time!"	Absorbed by the Gash: Julia and Frank; the erotics of the Order
Horror	Shudder, scream	Castration: "too early!"	Absorbed by the Gash: hooks, chains, the regeneration
Melodrama	Tears	Origins: "too late!"	Expelled by the Order and returned as Lament: Kirsty, "Jesus wept," the box's name

Hellraiser fuses pornography and horror under the Cenobitic operator and expels melodrama, whose bodily sign the Order forbids. Melodrama returns nonetheless, in the bond of daughter and father, in Frank's last words, and in the name of the box. The film is thus a site at which the body genres meet and their hierarchy is contested: the Gash governs pornography and horror, and the Lament is melodrama's re-

venge. Melodrama's temporality, the "too late" of grief for what is already lost, is precisely what the Cenobitic eternal present cannot admit.

8.4 *The Spectator as Solver: Horror's Autotheory*

Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror, or Paradoxes of the Heart* (1990) asked why audiences seek what repels them, and answered that horror narratives are "erotetic," structured by questions of disclosure and confirmation whose cognitive pleasure repays the disgust occasioned by monsters that are categorically interstitial. Carroll drew the notion of interstitiality from Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966), for which impurity is category violation. The Cenobites are fusion figures of exceptional density: priest and torturer, angel and demon, male and female, flesh and geometry. Edmund Burke's *Enquiry* (1757) had held that terror becomes a source of sublime delight only when danger is kept at a certain distance; Pasolini's binoculars (Chapter Six) are the emblem of that distance. The box annuls it. It is the device that abolishes the aesthetic interval.

The Cenobites' promise of sights never before seen is cinema's own promise, and the film thereby stages its apparatus. The box is the screen; solving is viewing; Frank is the spectator, the connoisseur of horror whose exhausted palate demands ever stronger stimulation, as the escalating "horrality" of 1980s cinema demanded of its audience. Laura Mulvey located a sadistic voyeurism in narrative cinema; Gaylyn Studlar, drawing on Deleuze's Masoch, and Carol Clover, drawing on the slasher film, identified a masochistic spectatorship. *Hellraiser*'s spectator oscillates, sadistic before the hooks and masochistic in identification with Kirsty. More fundamentally, the Cenobitic operator describes the spectatorial economy of horror itself. Horror audiences value the magnitude of affect irrespective of its sign; the paradox of horror dissolves once spectatorship is recognized as an absolute-value operation. *Hellraiser* is horror's autotheory, and it even predicts its own reception: the box's return to the market in the final scene prefigures the sequels the market would demand.

Aristotle's catharsis proceeds through pity and fear. The Cenobites retain the magnitude of fear and abolish pity, *eleos*, the emotion of lament. Kirsty restores it. The film's catharsis is therefore partial, routed through the one character who refuses the Order's interdiction of tears.

8.5 *Mourning and Melancholia: Julia's Refusal, Kirsty's Work*

In "Trauer und Melancholie" (1917), Freud described mourning as the work by which the libido is withdrawn, piece by piece, from a lost object, under the verdict of reality that the object no longer exists. Melancholia refuses the verdict; the lost object is incorporated into the ego, whose impoverishment Freud figured as the shadow of the object falling upon it. Julia is the melancholic. She cannot mourn Frank, and her incorporation is literal: she feeds him bodies until the lost object stands in the room. Melancholia becomes resurrection. Kirsty is the mourner. She loses her father and must accept, in an instant, reality's verdict that the man in her father's skin is not her father. Her refusal of the paternal skin is the work of mourning compressed into an act of recognition.

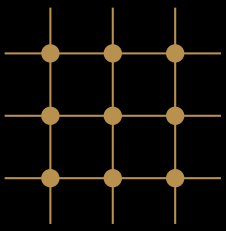
The name of the device holds the alternative. Solved forward, the Lament Configuration annihilates the sign of loss; solved in reverse, by Kirsty, it performs the work of mourning. The box contains both operations, and its name is that of the second.

8.6 *Re-signation: Resignation, the Face, and the Ethics of the Lament*

This thesis names the counter-operation *re-signation*, and the term is deliberately double. In its first sense, re-signation is the restoration of sign to experience: the insistence that suffering is not mere intensity but loss, that pleasure and pain differ, that good and evil differ, and that these differences are not illusions imposed on a sign-less substrate but the achievements of a creature that mourns. In its second sense, it is resignation as Kierkegaard defined it in *Frygt og Bæven* (1843). The knight of infinite resignation renounces the finite object of his love while preserving the love itself, and finds his eternal consciousness in

that renunciation. Kirsty's resignation inverts the movement. She renounces not the finite but the infinite the box offers, and accepts the finite with its losses. Her resignation is not passivity but the most difficult act in the mythos: the refusal of the absolute value.

Emmanuel Levinas's *Totalité et infini* (1961) supplies the final term. The face of the Other is not its plastic form but an expression that exceeds every image of it, and its first word is a command: thou shalt not kill. Frank can wear Larry's skin; he cannot wear his face, in Levinas's sense, and Kirsty perceives the absence of the face beneath the skin. The lead Cenobite's face, gridded and pinned, is a face converted into a map, the *visage* rendered as *res extensa*. It does not command; it measures. Re-signation is therefore also the restoration of the face. The Lament Configuration is the box in which both operations are stored. Solved forward, it is the Gash. Solved in reverse, it is the Lament.



Chapter Nine

The Hidden Abode

Libidinal Political Economy of the Configuration

9.1 Le Marchand: Commodity, Fetish, Bazaar
9.2 The Eden of Bentham and the Hidden Abode
9.3 Intensity as General Equivalent
9.4 Restricted and General Economy: The Cenobites as Accountants
9.5 Coda: The Configuration Now

9.1 *Le Marchand: Commodity, Fetish, Bazaar*

The film opens and closes in a bazaar. Frank purchases the box; in the final scene, the merchant offers it again to a new customer, inviting him to name his pleasure. The mythos is framed, literally, by an act of sale. Its maker's name is *le marchand*, which *Bloodline* renders as a dynasty named Merchant; the novella's intermediary brokered the box as esoteric knowledge, the film's merchant as goods. Marx opened *Das Kapital* (1867) with the observation that a commodity appears at first sight a trivial thing, but on analysis proves to be, in the English translation of 1887, "a very queer thing, abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties." The Configuration is the commodity whose theological niceties are literal. It really is a portal to the metaphysical. And as the commodity, for Marx, conceals behind a relation between things the social relations of the labour that produced it, so the box conceals behind its lacquered surface a realm of worked bodies.

The bazaar is orientalized. The film sources its box from an "East" constructed, in the terms Said analysed, as the repository of forbidden sensuality, the imaginary geography that drew Flaubert to Egypt and Burton to the erotic texts he translated. The colonial economy of desire is the box's supply chain. The family name extends the resonance. Liverpool, Barker's native city, grew rich in the eighteenth century on the Atlantic slave trade and in the nineteenth on the import of slave-grown American cotton: a commodity soaked in the blood of the bodies that produced it. The Cottons' floorboards drink blood. The resonance is flagged as such, but it organizes a truth the film does not state. Behind every commodity's gleam lies an abode of bodies.

9.2 *The Eden of Bentham and the Hidden Abode*

In the sixth chapter of *Das Kapital*, Marx describes the sphere of circulation, where labour-power is bought and sold, as "a very Eden of the innate rights of man," where alone there rule "Freedom, Equality, Property and Bentham." To understand how value is produced, he insists, one must leave this noisy sphere and follow the parties into "the

hidden abode of production," on whose threshold hangs the notice "No admittance except on business." Frank lives in the Eden of Bentham. He is free, he contracts, he owns, and he calculates his pleasures exactly as the felicific calculus prescribes (Chapter Two). The box is the notice on the threshold, and beyond it lies the hidden abode, where bodies are worked. The hooks and chains that take Frank are the implements of the industrial abattoir, the meat hook of the slaughterhouse that Upton Sinclair's *The Jungle* (1906) made into an emblem of the human body processed as carcass. The Cenobitic realm is the hidden abode rendered as theology: the place where the capacities of the body are extracted to their limit.

Jean-François Lyotard's *Économie libidinale* (1974) opens with an imperative, *Ouvrez le prétendu corps et étalez toutes ses surfaces*, open the so-called body and spread out all its surfaces, unfolding skin, membranes, and organs into a single ephemeral libidinal band. Frank, spread across the hooks at the corners of the room, is that opening rendered as image. The same book contains a notorious provocation, widely and justly criticized: the claim that the English proletariat of the industrial revolution enjoyed, hysterically and masochistically, the exhaustion of their bodies in mines and foundries. *Hellraiser* renders Lyotard's opening as image and his provocation as fable. In a Britain undergoing deindustrialization, a culture that had worked bodies to exhaustion imagines a sublime of exhaustion, and imagines it, characteristically, as something one purchases.

9.3 *Intensity as General Equivalent*

Money, for Marx, is the general equivalent: the commodity in which all qualitatively different use-values are expressed as quantities of a single substance. Georg Simmel's *Philosophie des Geldes* (1900) traced the cultural consequences of this reduction of quality to quantity, and his essay "Die Großstädte und das Geistesleben" (1903) identified its subjective correlate in the blasé attitude (*Blasiertheit*) of the metropolitan, whose nerves, overstimulated, can no longer react with appropriate energy, so that things appear uniformly flat and grey and none seems

worthy of preference. Frank is Simmel's blasé man, his capacity for discrimination exhausted by a metropolis of stimuli.

The homology can now be stated as the political-economic content of this thesis. The absolute-value operator is the libidinal analogue of the money-form. As money abolishes the qualitative difference among use-values in favour of a single quantity, the Configuration abolishes the qualitative difference between pleasure and pain in favour of a single intensity. Intensity is the general equivalent of affect. The Cenobites are what affect becomes under the money-form: experience convertible without remainder into a single measure, and valued by that measure alone.

9.4 *Restricted and General Economy: The Cenobites as Accountants*

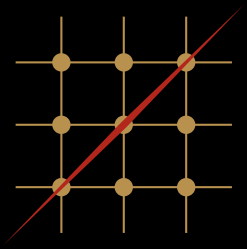
Bataille's *La Part maudite* (1949) distinguished the restricted economy of utility and accumulation from the general economy of expenditure without return, arguing that every system produces a surplus that must finally be spent in luxury, festival, sacrifice, or war. The Cenobites wear the costume of the general economy: sacrifice, laceration, the prodigal waste of bodies. Their interdiction of tears (Chapter Eight) exposes a restricted economy beneath the costume. Suffering is not to be wasted; it is to be conserved. The franchise's celebrated promise that a victim's suffering will be legendary even in Hell speaks the language of accumulation and renown, of suffering stored as value and converted into reputation. The Order is capital in theological form. It converts all qualitative experience into a single quantitative medium and accumulates it. This resolves the apparent contradiction of beings at once ecstatic and economical, and it shows that Barker's Hell is not the outside of the economy but its truth.

9.5 *Coda: The Configuration Now*

Four decades after the novella, the most widely handled box in the world is a slab of black glass, lit from within by gold and coloured geometry, manipulated by fingertips sliding panels across its surface. The platforms it opens onto are optimized for engagement, a metric indif-

ferent to sign: outrage and delight, grief and arousal register alike as interaction. Engagement is an absolute value. The Cenobitic operator has become an operating principle, and what B. Joseph Pine and James Gilmore named the experience economy (1999) has matured into a market for intensity as such, in which users scrolling toward a stronger stimulus repeat Frank's itinerary in miniature. Bruckner's 2022 reboot, whose seeker is a wealthy man in pursuit of the box's ultimate gift, registers the shift: capital has become the Frank Cotton of the age.

The argument does not require apocalyptic rhetoric; it requires only the recognition that a culture which measures affect by magnitude alone has adopted the Order's axiology without its liturgy. The critical task follows from the thesis. Re-signation, the restoration of valence, judgment, and mourning, is not only an ethics for the solver of a fictional box. It is a practice of attention in an economy built on the absolute value.



Conclusion

Between the Gash and the Lament

This thesis began with a man too absorbed in his puzzle to hear a bell. It ends with the puzzle returned to a merchant's stall and offered to a stranger with an invitation to name his pleasure. Between those two scenes, the mythos constructs a metaphysics, and this study has attempted to state it with the rigour it deserves.

That metaphysics is lacerative order. Its central operation, the absolute value, abolishes the sign of experience while preserving and maximizing its magnitude. Its emblem is the pin at the intersection of the grid, a coordinate that is also a wound. Its genealogy fuses three traditions that Western thought had kept apart: the transgressive lineage that runs from Sade through Bataille to Foucault, the ascetic-mystical lineage that runs from the desert cenobia through Teresa and Julian to Nietzsche's ascetic priest, and the combinatorial-rationalist lineage that runs from Llull and Kircher to Descartes and Kant. It fuses them, moreover, in a single institution, the cenobium of the Gash, which is at once a monastery, a court, a combinatorial engine, and a community of the wound. Its scandal is threefold: the infinite that desire seeks exists, it is sign-less, and it is reached not by chaos but by order. Its distinctive contribution to the history of infernal imagination is to have replaced Dante's just contrapasso, Milton's sovereign mind, and Lovecraft's indifferent cosmos with an attentive, lawful, and post-moral Order that gives desire exactly what it asks, minus the assumption that what it asks is good.

The mythos does not, however, endorse the operation it describes. It inscribes the counter-operation in the very name of its device. The Configuration is a dialectical object. Solved forward, it is the Gash; solved in reverse, it is the Lament. Frank and Julia are figures of the forward solution, the one completing the catalogue of experience, the other refusing to mourn and resurrecting what she should have let go. Kirsty is the figure of the reverse: the mourner, the recognizer of the face beneath the skin, the one who renounces the infinite and accepts the finite with its losses. The interdiction of tears, Frank's dying citation of the weeping Christ, and the drift of the box's name from merchant to lament form a single argument that the critical literature has not assembled, and that this thesis places at the centre of the mythos's ethics.

What the mythos teaches, then, is none of the lessons that its precursors drew. It does not teach, with Epicurus, that desire should be moderated, nor, with Bataille and Foucault, that transgression is sovereign, nor, with the monastic Rule, that order saves. It does not even teach, with Blake's *Marriage of Heaven and Hell*, that "The road of excess leads to the palace of wisdom." That proverb is the Cenobites' creed, and the mythos confirms it: the palace exists, and it is Hell. Blake also wrote that "If the doors of perception were cleansed every thing would appear to man as it is, Infinite." The Cenobites cleanse the doors of perception with blades, and the infinite appears. What Blake did not foresee is that the infinite, perceived without sign, is indistinguishable from torment.

The human being, in this mythos, is defined neither as the creature that desires the infinite, as in Augustine, nor as the creature that transgresses, as in Bataille, but as the creature that weeps: the one who resigns. Frank's last words concede as much. Even the damned know that tears are the one thing the Order cannot accept.

The box goes back to the bazaar, and the merchant asks the next customer to name his pleasure. The question is the mythos's final provocation and its reader's inheritance, for every reader of horror stands at that stall. The question is a trap only on the assumption that pleasure has a sign that intensity will respect. To answer the merchant well is to answer with the Lament. Hell, in Barker, is the absolute value of the heart; lament is its sign.

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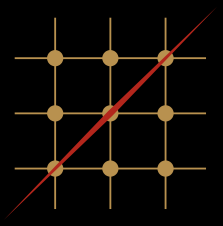
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Keywords

Clive Barker; *Hellraiser*; *The Hellbound Heart*; Cenobites; Order of the Gash; Lament Configuration; lacerative order; absolute-value operator; sign-annihilation; proper intensity; re-signation; hyperincarnation; infernal legalism; geometric sovereignty; intensity as general equivalent; body horror; abjection; jouissance; limit-experience; transgression; ascetic ideal; cenobitic monasticism; *penthos* and the gift of tears; *mysterium tremendum*; sadomasochism; Sade; Masoch; Bataille; Foucault; Deleuze; Kristeva; Nietzsche; Kierkegaard; ars combinatoria; Athanasius Kircher; Marsyas; contrapasso; Faust; Gothic; cosmic horror; body genres; Final Girl; melodrama; mourning and melancholia; libidinal economy; commodity fetishism; attention economy; comparative mythology; queer theory; horror studies; philosophy of horror.



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